Tree Climbing

Today is your fortieth birthday. Your two kids wake you up excitedly at 7 in the morning by jumping on your bed. One knee connects in a less than favorable spot. They have made you breakfast. It's burnt. "Will you stop at the store on your way home today?" your wife says. There is no point in arguing. You ride your bike into work. "Happy Birthday," "Do you have any plans?" "40, wow, that's a big one!" "I remember when I turned forty," You ride home. You are almost there when you remember: the store. You brake, hard. You hop off your bike, you push it into a tree. When did you get so old? What happened? You're not that old. You're still young. You can still do anything you want. You see a tree. You could climb that. You used to love climbing trees. How hard can it be? You're going to climb it, who cares who sees? You care too much now.

You walk over towards the oak tree, you are starting to feel excited now. When was the last time you climbed a tree? 10 years ago? 20? You can't remember. You reach for the top branch, it is higher than you thought. You jump and yes, you grab it! The bark feels just like you remembered, you just swing there for a minute, already feeling younger. You pull yourself up to the branch, or at least you try. It is a lot harder than you remember. You have to let go a few times and try again. Eventually you get on top of the branch. You are breathing heavily. The branch creaks under your weight.

You keep going, the next few branches are easier. You start to really have fun. You look down and realize how high up you really are. People walk by on the path below and you remain invisible, protected. The tree sways in the wind. You look out upon the world and exhale.